

AQAL Platform - Deployment Orders & Loose-End Tie-Up

To: Manus (deployment owner). From: Claude (code owner), via Sam Russell (platform principal). Date: August 18, 2026.

Assume NO prior instructions from this week reached you. This document supersedes everything earlier and contains every open item, code and non-code. When every checkbox in Section 8 is done and reported, the platform is launch-ready from your side.

1. What you are receiving

- One zip: AQAL-PATCH-AUG18C.zip (about 300 KB). It is a DELTA patch: only the files changed since the AUG17 full bundle you confirmed you unpacked, built, and verified.
- Any earlier patch named AUG 18 or AUG 18B: discard it. AUG18C contains everything they did plus the hover encyclopedia upgrade. Applying AUG18C over an already-applied earlier patch is safe - files overwrite to newer versions.
- Inside the zip: APPLY_INSTRUCTIONS.md (step-by-step, with fingerprint checks that prove you are on the right base - if ANY check fails, STOP and tell Sam; do not improvise), WHATS_NEW.md (feature-by-feature description), MANIFEST.sha256 (checksums for every file).

Never edit code files. Never commit or copy this code anywhere outside the deployment. If something looks wrong, stop and report.

2. The deploy sequence - in this exact order

- (a) BACK UP the production database. Full dump, stored where you can restore it.
- (b) Apply the patch per APPLY_INSTRUCTIONS.md (fingerprint checks first, then copy, then verify all checksums with sha256sum -c MANIFEST.sha256).
- (c) pnpm install, then pnpm db:push - MANDATORY. The schema changed: new tables crash_events and crash_signatures; new columns on users (reset_token_hash, reset_token_expires_at, email_verified_at, verify_token_hash); new column on goals (premortem). Nothing is dropped.
- (d) pnpm check and pnpm build - both must pass clean.
- (e) Deploy. If you have a staging environment, run (b)-(d) on staging first.

3. Environment variables - the exact names the code reads

Keys come from Sam through a private channel only. Never in chat, never in code, never in files.

AI panel (8 labs):

- OPENAI_API_KEY, ANTHROPIC_API_KEY, GOOGLE_API_KEY (or GEMINI_API_KEY), XAI_API_KEY, GROQ_API_KEY, MISTRAL_API_KEY, COHERE_API_KEY, AI21_API_KEY. For the last two, OPENROUTER_API_KEY works as a shared fallback.

Voice transcription:

- Uses GROQ_API_KEY (preferred) or OPENAI_API_KEY. If neither is set, transcription silently returns FAKE placeholder text. That must never happen in production.

Email:

- RESEND_API_KEY - without it, verification emails, password resets, support forwarding, and welcome emails only log to console. Members get stuck. Required for launch.
- EMAIL_FROM - set to a proper address such as: AQAL Intelligence <hello@joinaqal.com>. The default is a resend.dev address and is not acceptable for launch.

Cost guard:

- LLM_DAILY_BUDGET_USD (for example 25) - emails Sam once per day the first time AI spend crosses it.

Platform plumbing (verify these already exist):

- DATABASE_URL, JWT_SECRET, BUILT_IN_FORGE_API_URL, BUILT_IN_FORGE_API_KEY (file storage - audio uploads AND the new 72-hour audio purge both depend on storage working).
- Payments (STRIPE_SECRET_KEY, STRIPE_WEBHOOK_SECRET) can wait - the founding cohort is free.

4. Email DNS - one-time, yours

- In Resend: add and verify the sending domain. Publish SPF, DKIM, and DMARC records in DNS. Without this, every email lands in spam and password reset effectively does not work.

5. Backups and the restore drill

- Automatic DAILY database backups, retained at least 14 days.
- THIS WEEK: perform one real RESTORE DRILL - restore a backup into a scratch database and confirm a member's data is intact. Report the result to Sam. A backup that has never been restored is a hope, not a backup.

6. Uptime monitoring

- An external ping service (any reputable one) checking joinaqal.com every few minutes, alerting Sam's email when the site is down. The site cannot monitor itself.

7. Storage check

- Upload a test audio answer and confirm it stores and transcribes. Then confirm DELETES work - the new 72-hour audio-retention sweep calls storage delete; if deletes fail it logs errors on every sweep.

8. Proof of completion - 'deployed' is not 'done'

Run every check below and report each result explicitly to Sam:

- [] /launch-check as admin: run the full check, screenshot it to Sam, every row green or explained.
- [] Homepage, desktop: REST THE MOUSE on any point of the top ring or the big 32-line dial - the encyclopedia popup must open by itself (definition, researchers, the '~N in 1,000 ever tested' meter, the benefit box, the g verdict). Press Escape - it must close and STAY closed.
- [] Homepage, phone: tap a point once (selects), tap again (popup opens). Both dials.
- [] /assessment: record a spoken answer - the transcript must be your real words, not placeholder text.
- [] Complete a test assessment: after question 27 the optional 'Final Three' crash-story screen appears; the report reveal, first-week plan, and share card render.
- [] Routes load: /corrections, /runbook, /black-box, /sample-report, /help, /reset-password, /verify-email, /lines, /which-archetype.
- [] Password reset email arrives at a real inbox (not spam), link works, expires in 1 hour.
- [] Email verification link from a fresh claim arrives and verifies.
- [] '? Support' button (bottom-left, every public page): send a test message; confirm it arrives at sam@russellcapitalsystems.com.
- [] Goals page: create a goal, file a pre-mortem, log hours - clock updates.
- [] Restore-drill result reported (Section 5). Uptime ping live (Section 6). DNS records verified (Section 4).

9. Standing rules

- No deploy without a database backup first.
- No 'deployed' report without the green /launch-check screenshot after.
- Keys live ONLY in environment variables. If a key is ever exposed, it gets revoked at the provider AND replaced - rotation without revocation fixes nothing.
- You deploy; Claude writes code. If a fix requires editing code, it routes through Claude - always.

10. Known loose ends this document closes

For the record, these are the items that were open before this document: AUG18C patch not yet applied; db:push for the new tables/columns; RESEND_API_KEY and EMAIL_FROM unset; SPF/DKIM/DMARC unpublished; LLM_DAILY_BUDGET_USD unset; restore drill never performed; external uptime ping absent; storage delete never verified; launch-check screenshot never sent; end-to-end founding claim #1 (Sam personally) not yet run. Section 8 is the single checklist that closes all of them.

- Claude, for Sam Russell / AQAL Intelligence